

UNDERDAWG • INDIA MARKET RESEARCH • OCTOBER 2026

Do these 18 features help artists get discovered?

Feature validation for an artists-only platform in India. Indian evidence first.

18 features tested

14 platforms compared

180+ Indian sources

THE BIG ANSWER

The plan as written does not deliver discovery.

It is mostly a money and Instagram toolkit. It helps artists who already have fans.

Only 3 of 18 features put an unknown artist in front of new people: **Hire Artists, Gigs** and a rebuilt **Show & Review**.

WHAT SHOULD CHANGE

Become the place where the right people find unknown artists

Keep

Instagram connection for import, the link page, Hire Artists and Gigs, Show & Review, Artist Boards, UPI payments on the web.

Change

Show & Review becomes artist and curator review. Insights become a verified credibility card. Pro sells tools, never reach.

Add

A free first-audience queue, verified curators, bookers and brands, an India-first opportunity board, a no-pay-for-reach rule.

Drop

Fan Club, scheduling, DM automation in the MVP, the template marketplace, in-house ticketing, any paid visibility.

Launch in one city with 3 to 5 crafts, partly run by hand.

India: a huge audience, many creators, and very little money reaching them

481M

people reached by Instagram in India. YouTube reaches 500M.

4.0–4.4M

active creators. 61% are nano creators with 1,000 to 10,000 followers.

8–10%

of creators monetise effectively (BCG).

15.2%

of creators are registered for GST or as a business.

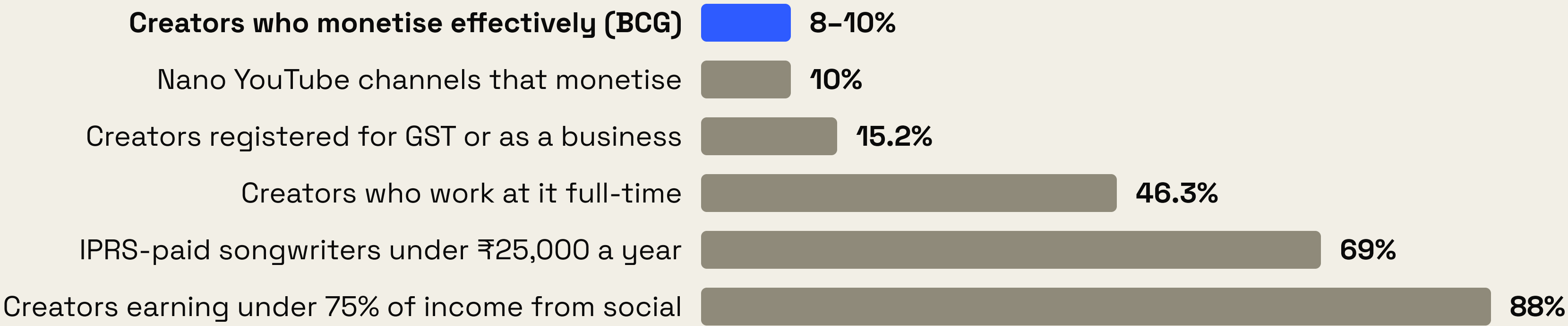
₹14,500 cr

organised live events in 2025, up 44% in a year.

₹163 cr

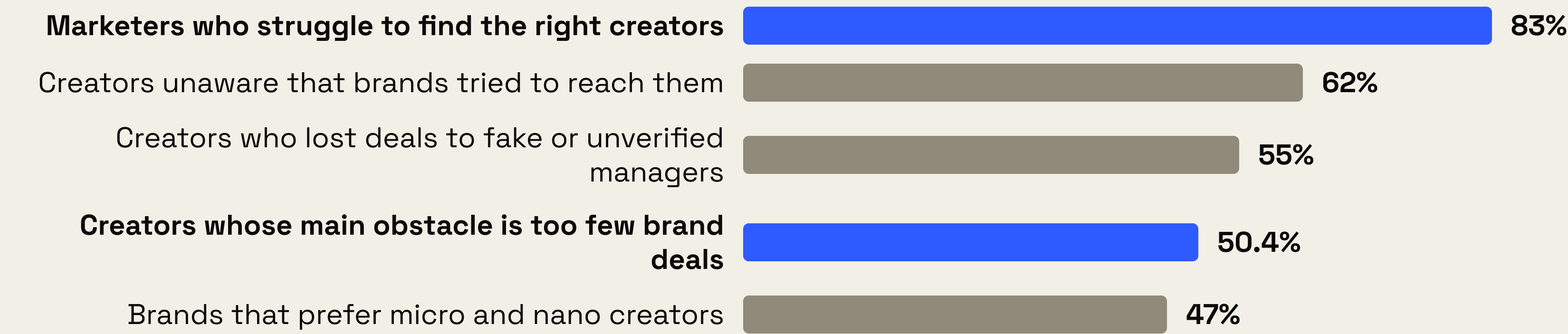
contemporary art, out of ₹2,543 crore of Indian art auctions in 2025.

Only 8 to 10% of India's creators earn real money



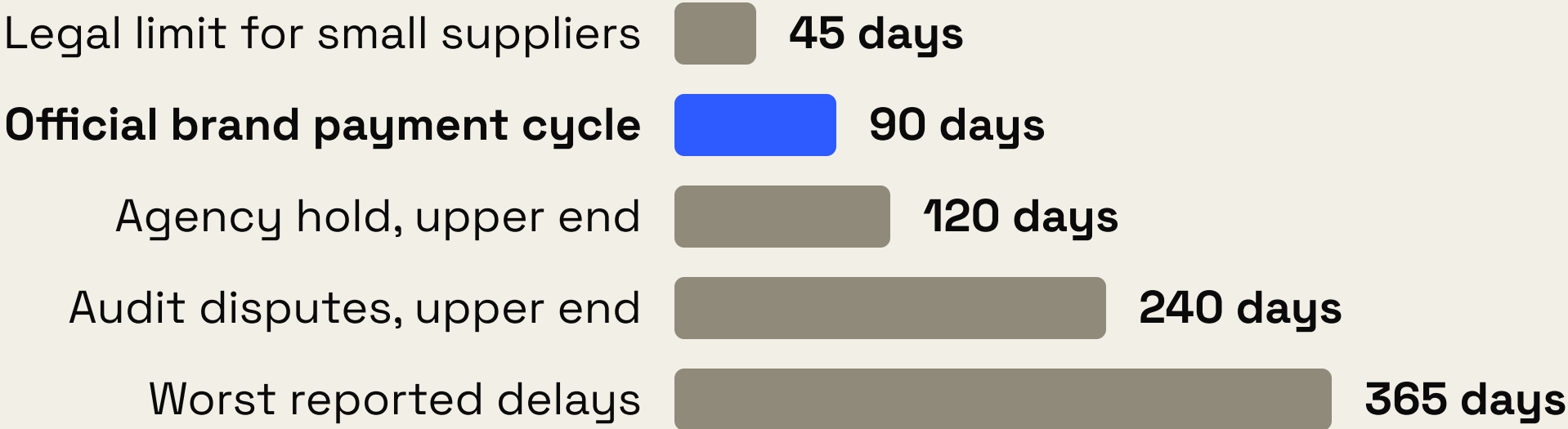
No Indian data exists on what visual artists, dancers or photographers earn. A tool that collects fan money has little to collect for most artists.

83% of Indian marketers cannot find the right creators; half of creators lack deals



Brand money also flows upward: a nano creator gets ₹1,000 to 12,000 per Reel, a mega creator ₹8 lakh or more.

Indian brands pay creators in 90 days to a year; the legal limit is 45 days



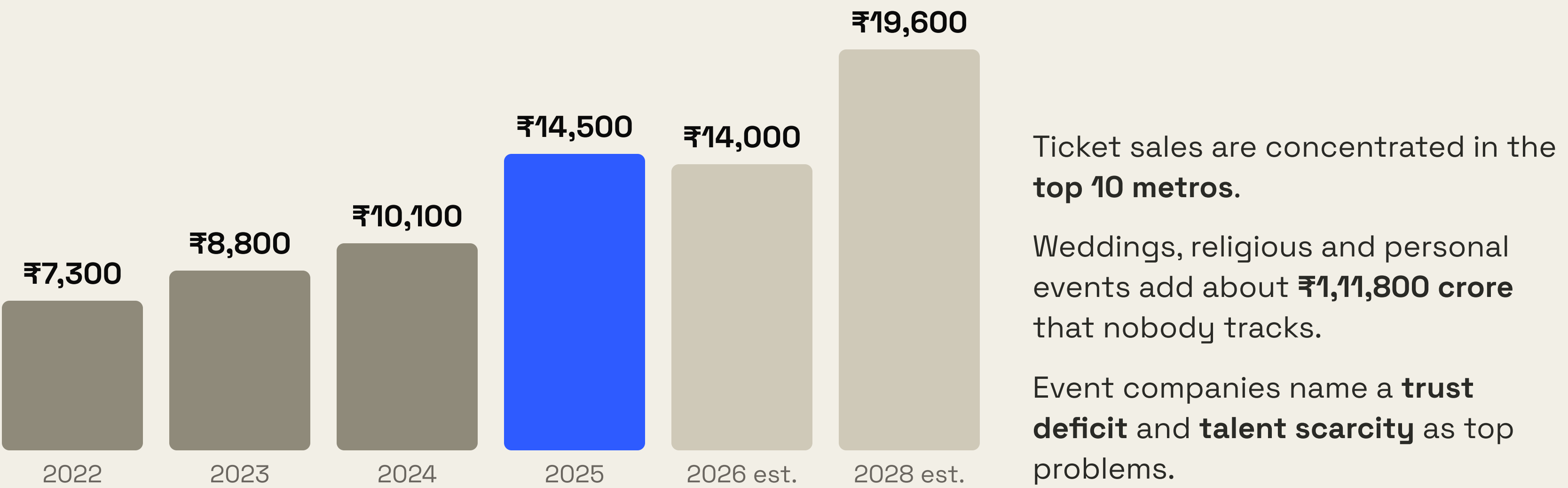
₹22,495 cr

lost to cyber fraud in India in 2025, up from ₹2,290 crore in 2022.

₹1,000–75,000

taken per victim by fake casting agents in Delhi and Mumbai cases.

India's organised live events doubled to ₹14,500 crore in three years



Source: FICCI-EY Media and Entertainment report, Mar 2026. ₹ crore a year. 2025 includes ₹2,500 crore from the Kumbh Mela.

Build 3 early, test 1, hold 1, and drop or defer the rest

#	Feature	Decision	What to do
1	Instagram-connected profile	Build early	Import, curate and tag work; accept non-Instagram work
2	Insights and verified engagement	Build early	A verified credibility card for brands; no leaderboards
3	Schedule posts to Instagram	Deprioritise	Skip; Instagram does it free
4	Link-in-bio page	Build early	Narrow: brand view, hire form, UPI support, free download
5	Templates and marketplace	Combine	Free in the link page, premium in Pro; no marketplace
6	Instagram DM automation	Deprioritise	Not in the MVP; crowded and capped by Meta
7	Art Shop	Experiment	Shop-lite first: prepaid, artist ships; held payments later
8	Live Rooms	After PMF	Critique and showcase rooms on third-party video
9	Fan Club	Reject	Needs fans that unknown artists do not have

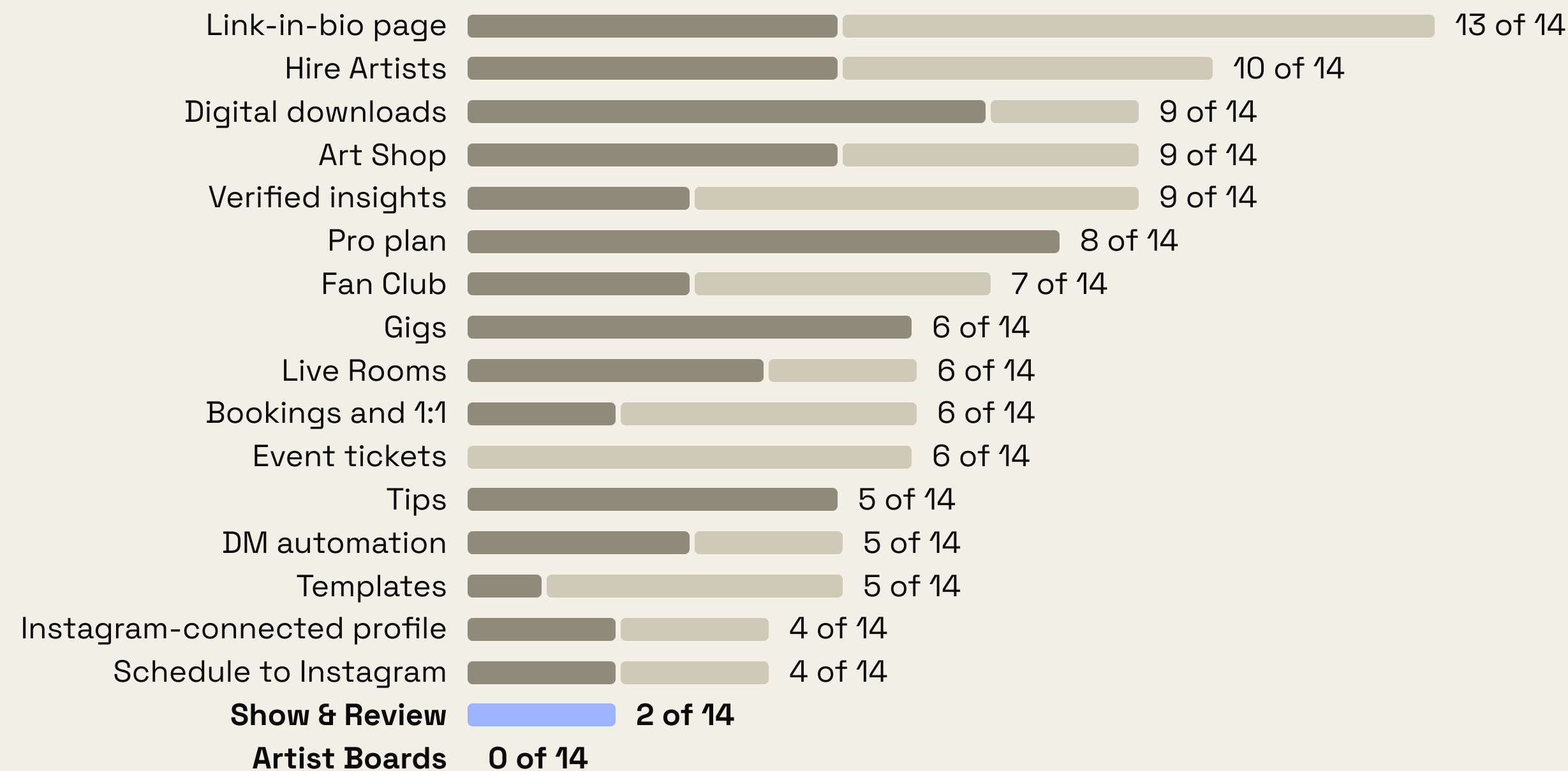
PMF = product-market fit: proof that artists and opportunity-givers keep coming back.

The strongest bets: Show & Review, Artist Boards and Opportunities

#	Feature	Decision	What to do
10	Show & Review	Build early	Artist-to-artist critique plus a curator queue
11	Artist Boards	Build early	Rate Check and scam alerts first; brand reviews later
12	Tips (UPI)	Combine	A zero-fee Support block on the link page
13	Digital downloads	Build early	Free download for an email now; paid files later
14	Bookings and 1:1 sessions	Experiment	Pilot paid portfolio reviews and music lessons
15	Event tickets	Deprioritise	List events and link out; no in-house ticketing
16	Hire Artists	Experiment	Merge with Gigs into one Opportunities marketplace
17	Gigs	Experiment	Verified posters, budget shown, free capped applications
18	Pro plan (₹299 a month)	After PMF	Sell tools and fee waivers, never visibility

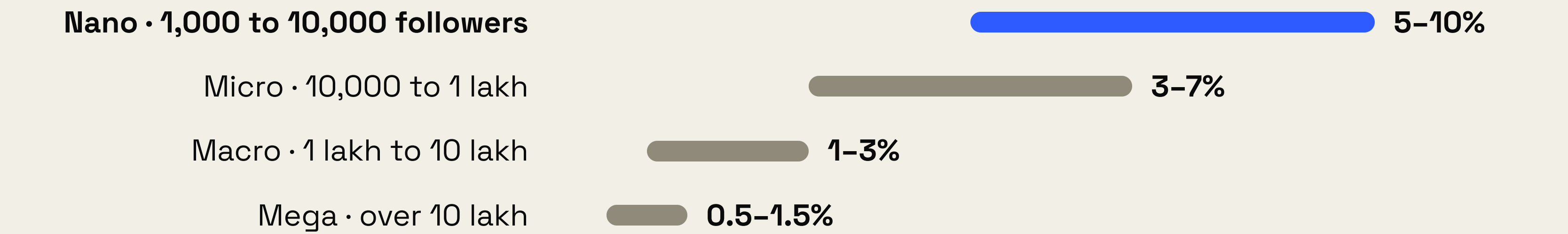
Hire Artists and Gigs are central to the MVP, as a hand-run pilot in one city.

Artist Boards: 0 of 14 platforms. Show & Review: only 2, partly.



Dark bar = strong, native. Light bar = partial. 14 platforms that work in India, checked 1 Oct 2026, including Instagram, YouTube, Topmate, StarClinch and Linktree.

In India, nano creators engage at 5 to 10%; mega creators at 0.5 to 1.5%



A card that shows engagement per reach, not follower counts, turns a small audience into a strength. **83% of Indian marketers** struggle to find the right creators.

Art Shop: start with Shop-lite, where the artist ships and is paid directly

1. List

Type, at least 3 real photos, size, price, dispatch time, shipping or local pickup.

2. Preview

An optional AI wall mockup at true scale, labelled as a visualisation.

3. Sell

A Shop block on the link page, and a button in Instagram DMs.

4. Pay

Prepaid only, into the artist's own payment account. 0% fee in the experiment.

5. Ship

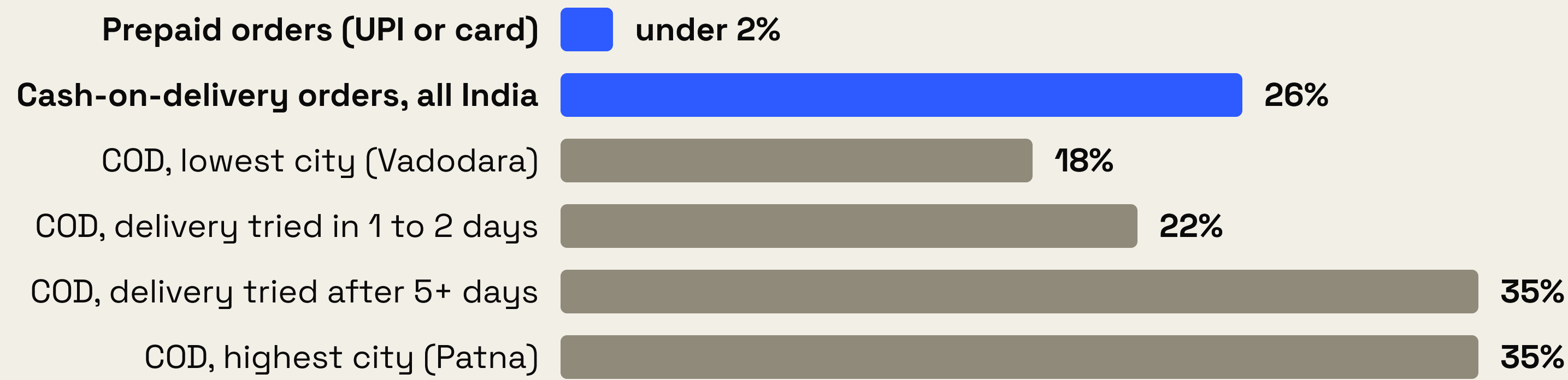
Packing checklist, then book a courier pickup or enter a tracking number.

6. Certify

On delivery the sale is verified. Originals get a digital certificate.

After product-market fit: a licensed payment aggregator holds the money and releases it 5 to 7 days after delivery. Fee about 8 to 10%.

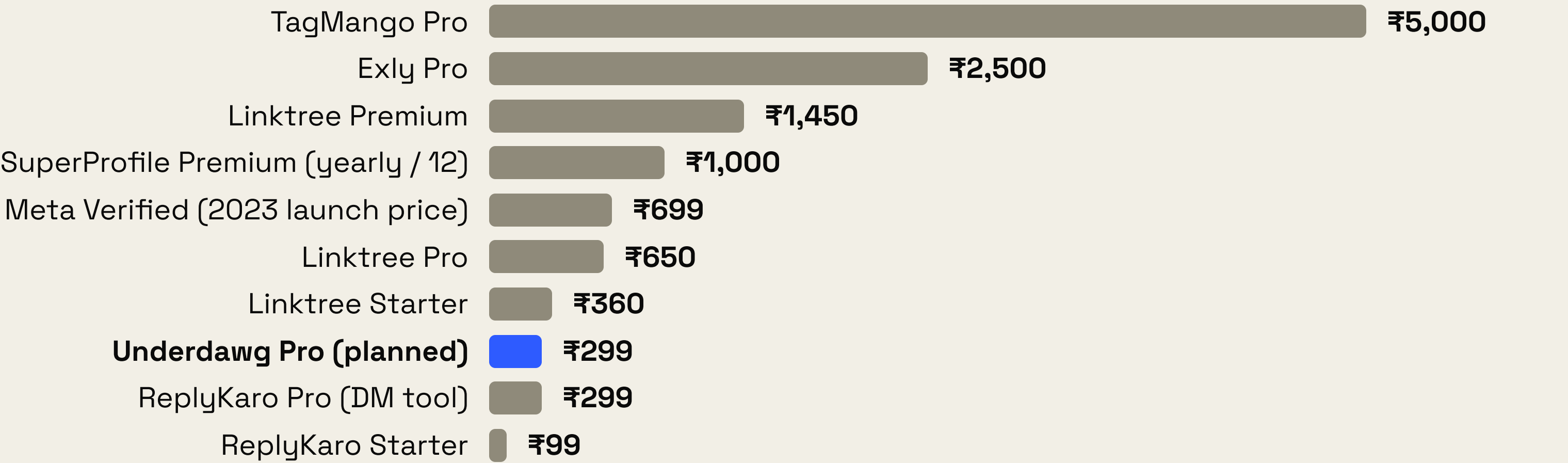
Cash-on-delivery orders come back 26% of the time; prepaid under 2%



So Shop-lite is prepaid only. Indian art sites are costly for artists: **Artflute takes 40%**, and Mojarto pays 21 working days after delivery.

Sources: Shipway via MediaBrief, FY25 (all Indian e-commerce, not art only); Artflute and Mojarto seller pages, Oct 2026

₹299 undercuts most Indian creator tools, but equals a plain DM tool



Price per month in rupees, checked Oct 2026. Pro should sell tools and fee waivers, never visibility.

One Opportunities marketplace, with two doors

1. Verified posters

A business check or KYC.
Favour cafés, venues,
colleges and agencies.

2. Budget shown

Craft, city, date and a
mandatory budget. Paid
work only.

3. Free to apply

Portfolio and a quote. A
weekly cap stops spam.

4. Fair shortlist

Blind first round,
newcomer slots, ranked
by fit and city.

5. Contract

Click to accept: date,
deliverables and
cancellation terms.

6. Advance held

By an RBI-authorized
payment aggregator, not
by Underdawg.

7. Release

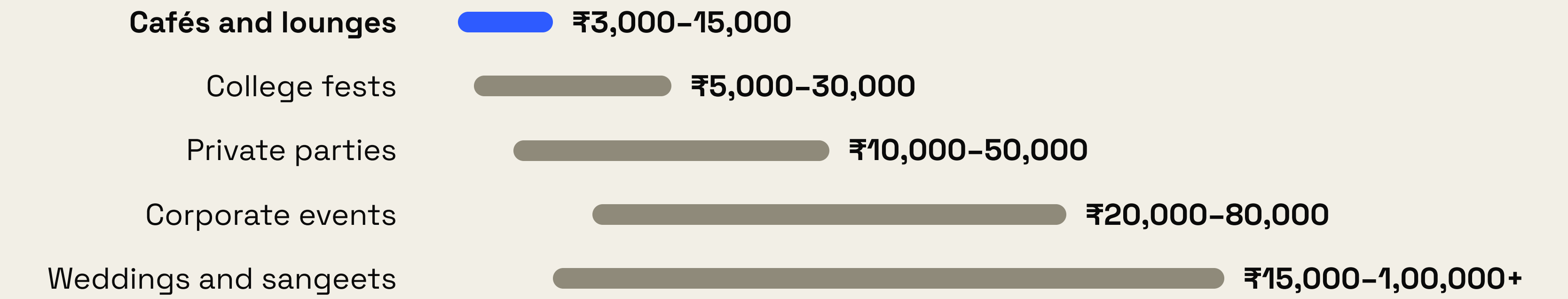
After the gig, or
automatically after a
short dispute window.

8. Ratings and fees

Two-way ratings. The
poster pays; artists pay
0%.

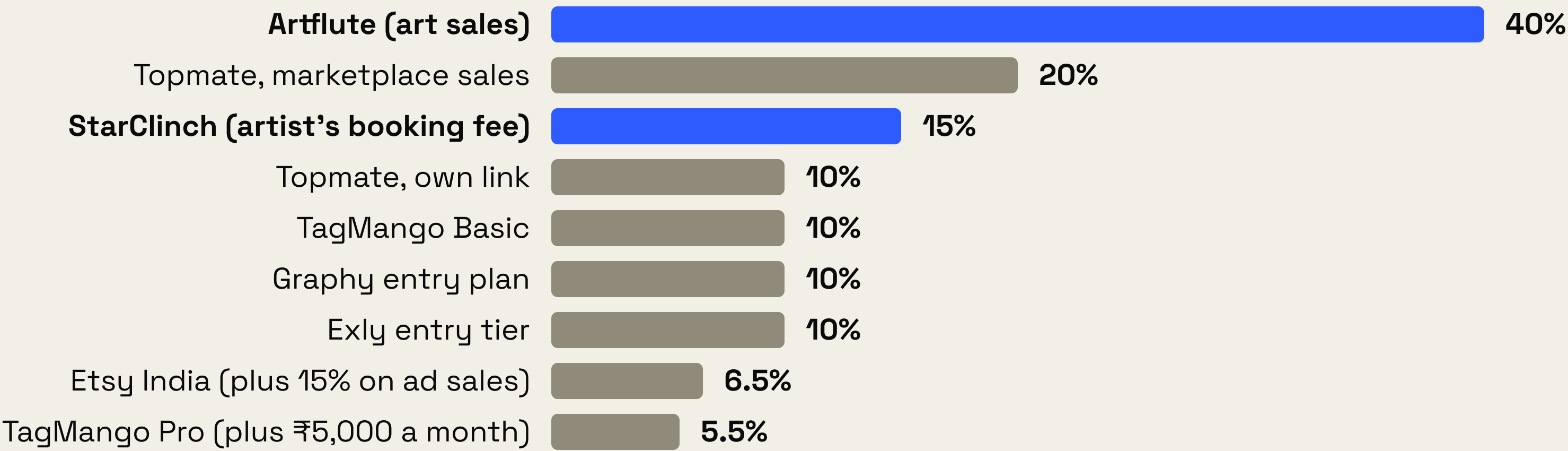
Door 1: hire this artist or send a brief. Door 2: post a gig or open call. Start by hand in one city; add escrow once posters come back.

A café gig pays an emerging musician ₹3,000 to 15,000; a wedding up to ₹1 lakh



These rupee ranges are the starting data for **Rate Check**. Comedians still pay ₹200 to 1,000 for an open-mic slot just to be seen.

Indian platforms take up to 40% of what artists and creators earn



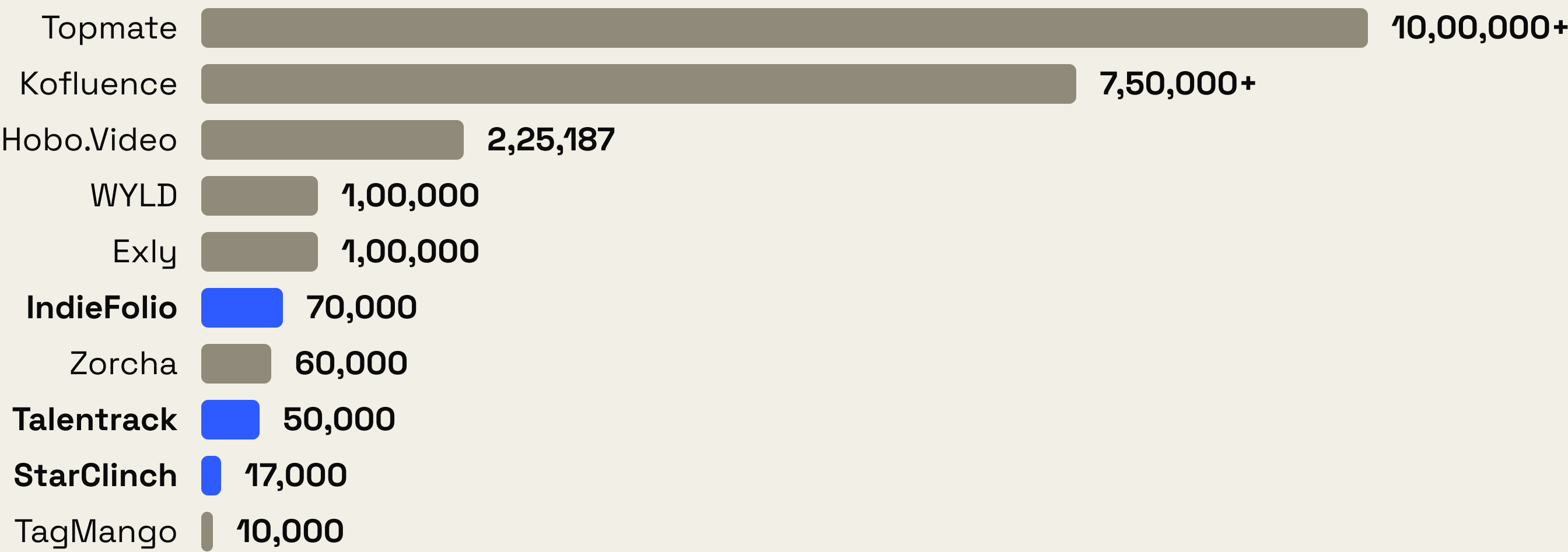
Blue = art and artist-booking platforms. Official pricing and terms pages, Oct 2026. Recommended for Underdawg: the poster pays, artists pay 0%.

Nobody in India builds this exact product, but most pieces already exist there

Indian company	Scale (company claim)	What it charges or earns	Overlaps with
Topmate	1M+ professionals	10–20% commission	Bookings, downloads, webinars, Instagram auto-DM
StarClinch	17,000+ artists	15% of the artist’s fee	Hire Artists, Gigs
Talentrack	50,000+ talent	FY25 revenue ₹36.4 crore	Hire Artists (casting and brand content)
IndieFolio	70,000+ talent	not published	Hire Artists (designers, illustrators)
Kofluence	7.5 lakh+ creators	FY25 revenue ₹52.5 crore	Brand deals for influencers
Hobo.Video and WYLD	2.25 lakh and 1 lakh	not published	Brand deals for small creators
TagMango, Exly, Graphy	10,000 to 2 lakh creators	10% or ₹2,500–30,000 a month	Fan Club, Live Rooms, downloads
Zorcha, ReplyKaro, InstantDM	10,000 to 60,000 users	from ₹99 a month	Instagram DM automation
Skillbox	FY25 revenue ₹29.9 crore	ticketing fees	Event tickets, music gigs
Artflute, Mojarto, MeMeraki	500+ master artists (MeMeraki)	Artflute takes 40%	Art Shop
Instagram (in India)	481M reach	free	Creator marketplace since Feb 2024, scheduling, bio links

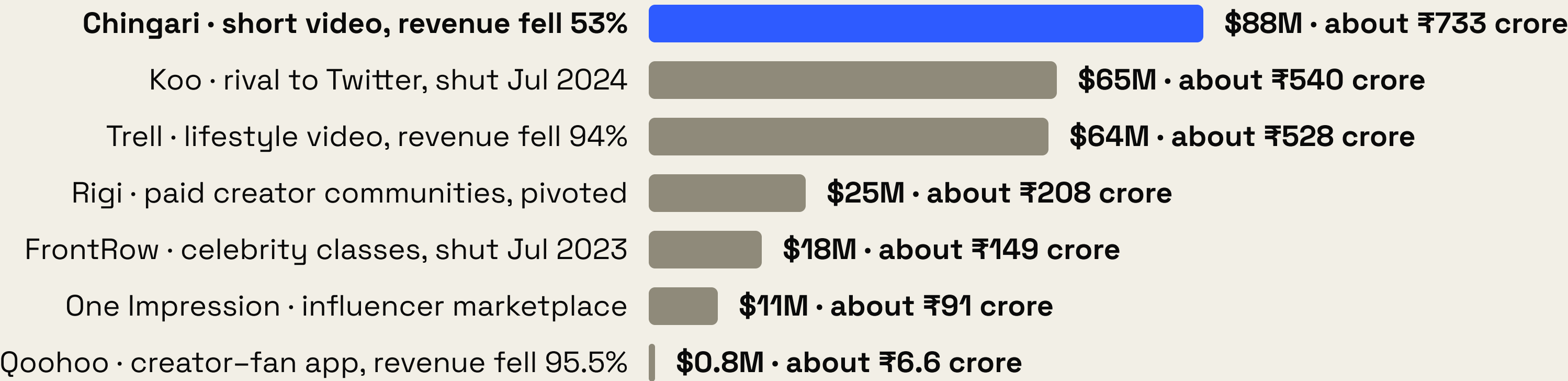
Global tools Indian artists also use: Linktree (earning tools not available in India), Beacons, Behance, BandLab, Cara.

Kofluence claims 7.5 lakh creators; artist-booking platforms claim 17,000 to 70,000



Blue = artist hiring and booking. Grey = brand-deal platforms and creator tools. All figures are company claims, Oct 2026. StarClinch’s story page says 10K+.

Indian creator startups that shut or shrank had raised up to ₹733 crore



Money raised, in US\$ as reported; rupees at about ₹83 per US\$. Sources: Inc42 Datalabs, Moneycontrol, Entrackr, TechCrunch.

Six lessons from Indian products that failed

Do not fight for feed time

Moj, Josh and Chingari lost their users to Instagram Reels and YouTube Shorts.

India-first is not a moat

Koo raised \$65M and shut in July 2024.

Fan-payment apps need fans first

Rigi pivoted away from paid communities. Qoohoo's revenue fell 95.5%.

Live teaching beats celebrity content

FrontRow shut; Artium earns ₹28 crore from live music classes.

Protect payouts first

Brands pay in 90 days to a year. Hold the poster's money before work starts.

Charge the demand side

Brands, hirers and organisers pay. Unknown artists pay 0%.

Also: never take AI-training rights over artists' work, and promise export and backups.

Eight missing pieces that would make discovery real

First-audience queue

Every new work is shown free to matched peers and one curator, booker or brand scout.

Newcomer bonus and caps

Published rules, so big accounts cannot dominate.

Curator review queue

With deadlines, and no pay-per-pitch for artists.

India-first opportunity board

Verified organisers and a free-to-apply filter.

Opportunity-giver search

By skill, style, city, language and budget.

Human-made evidence

Light proof of process, and a buyer filter.

No-pay-for-reach rule

Published on day one.

Portable portfolio

Export, plus fan contacts the artist owns.

Each one answers an artist problem the research found evidence for.

The MVP proves one sentence, in one city

In the MVP

- Profile: Instagram import and curation, tags, export
- Verified credibility card
- Narrow link page: brand view, hire form, UPI support
- Free first-audience review queue
- Verified curators, bookers and brands, searched by fit
- One Opportunities board: Hire, Gigs and open calls
- Rate Check, scam alerts and fairness rules

Out for now

- Scheduling and DM automation
- Template marketplace
- Escrowed shop
- Live Rooms and Fan Club
- Paid downloads and full bookings
- Ticketing and the Pro plan

The sentence: artists get discovery and opportunity through Underdawg that they do not get elsewhere.

From joining to a paid opportunity, in eight steps

1. Join

By invite. Connect Instagram or upload work by hand.

2. Profile

Curated work, the credibility card, the link page.

3. Upload

Send a work to the review queue, with a goal.

4. Discovery

Matched peers and one opportunity-giver see it, by a deadline.

5. Found

Through the queue, a weekly digest and search by fit.

6. Opportunity

A pick, a shortlist, a brief, a gig or an open-call selection.

7. Value

Feedback, a pick or a paid job, with verified completion.

8. Return

Alerts for briefs and gigs in their city and craft.

Measure: the share of artists who get a real opportunity within 90 days from someone they did not know.

Today there is no moat. Here is what could become one.

A network of opportunity-givers

Verified curators, bookers and brands in each city and craft. Slow to build, and impossible to copy as a feature.

Trust rules rivals cannot adopt

No pay-for-reach, no AI training on artists' work, no gated contact. Rivals earn from the opposite.

Data from before traction

Curator picks, critique scores, completed jobs, payments and Indian rates by craft and city.

The least-occupied position: **fair discovery of under-discovered artists by the people who create opportunities, across crafts, India-first.**

Grow by proof: one city, then density, then national scale

Year 1: prove it

About 1,000 artists, one city

- Profile, card and link page
- First-audience queue, by hand
- Curated opportunity board
- Rate Check and scam alerts
- Fairness rules and export

Year 2: build density

About 10,000 artists, 1 to 2 metros

- Self-serve Opportunities
- Escrow through an aggregator
- Automatic matching, benchmarks
- Paid curator and pro queue
- Shop, 1:1 sessions, Pro plan

Year 3: go national

About 100,000 artists

- National marketplace
- Brand reputation scores
- Rupee price suggestions
- Talent-scouting dashboard
- Pro as real revenue

Gate 1: posters come back and artists get work from strangers

Gate 2: enough artists per craft and city for self-serve hiring

Move to the next stage when the gate is met, not when the calendar says so. Artist numbers are estimates to test.

NEXT STEP

Test the riskiest assumption first

Will Indian brands, venues, colleges and curators hire **unknown** artists through Underdawg, again and again? No evidence was found either way.

- Recruit repeat opportunity-givers by hand in one city
- Ask for real briefs with real budgets, and run weekly shortlists by hand
- Measure briefs posted, posters who return, and hires of small-account artists

Confidence is moderate: many Indian creator numbers are company claims, and nobody has measured artist income by craft or the share of creators paid late.